

The Thumbnail Checklist

10 checks I run before uploading any video | Finance Unfiltered

- ☐ **1. One big idea only**
If you cannot describe what the thumbnail is about in five words, it is too busy. Cut everything that is not the idea.
- ☐ **2. Three words of text, max**
Big, bold, ALL-CAPS. It must be readable on a phone held at arm's length. Four or more words and nobody reads it.
- ☐ **3. A face with a strong emotion**
Shock, surprise, curiosity. A real human reaction beats a posed smile every time. No face? Use the most dramatic object in the video.
- ☐ **4. Hard contrast**
Bright subject on a dark background, or dark subject on a bright one. If the thumbnail blends into the page, it does not exist.
- ☐ **5. Test three versions, not one**
YouTube Studio lets you upload three thumbnails for one video. It rotates them across real viewers and keeps the winner. Stop guessing.
- ☐ **6. Thumbnail + title make ONE promise**
Together they should tell one story. Never repeat the same words in both - that wastes half your pitch.
- ☐ **7. Pass the stamp-size test**
Shrink it to the size of a postage stamp. If you cannot read it and feel the emotion at that size, redesign it.
- ☐ **8. Never lie**
The video must deliver what the thumbnail promises. Clickbait that disappoints kills watch time - and the algorithm notices.
- ☐ **9. Same look every time**
Same colors, same font, same style. Viewers start recognizing YOUR videos in the feed before they even read the title.
- ☐ **10. Study your niche's winners**
Screenshot the thumbnails in your niche with the most views. Write down what they share. That pattern is your starting template.

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